

PARSNIPS *Pastinaca sativa*

Sweet, delicious parsnips are excellent cooked in soups or stews, or roasted like potatoes. Although they are fairly slow to germinate, once established, they are a relatively low maintenance crop, and will reliably bear roots as long as they are sufficiently watered and have enough space. Roots are available in different shapes, sizes, and even colors, so try some unusual varieties.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Parsnips thrive in an open, sunny position, in light, sandy soil, with a slightly acidic pH of 6.5. They come in a range of shapes and sizes, so make sure that your soil is deep enough for whichever type you choose. Dig well-rotted manure into the soil the previous fall, and ensure that it is not too compacted.

Wait until mid- to late spring before sowing any seed. Sow directly into the soil about .75 in (2 cm) deep, either thinly along the row, or with two or three seeds together, since parsnips often germinate unreliably. Once the seedlings are established, thin to 4–6 in (10–14 cm) apart for medium roots, and 12 in (20 cm) for large.



Sow thinly to increase chances of success.

CROP CARE

Water your seeds regularly while they are germinating, then only water the developing roots if the ground is very dry. Roots may split if they are allowed to dry out and are then watered. Parsnips do not normally need feeding, but give them a liquid feed if growth is poor. Weed your parsnips carefully until they are established.